21 Use of Capital Letters

The letters of the alphabet can be written by using small or capital letters.

Capital letters are used in different ways and for different reasons. Given below are some uses of capital letters.

1. You know that proper nouns, that is, the names of particular persons, places, buildings, etc. start with capital letters:
   Akbar ***L***ondon ***G***eorge ***R***ome ***V***ikram
2. A surname is also spelt with an opening capital letter:
   Mahatma ***G***andhi Abraham ***L***incoln Nelson ***M***andela
3. If a name consists of more than one word, each word begins with a capital letter, unless it is a preposition:
   *Atlantic **O**cean* *West **I**ndies* *Gulf of **M**exico*
   *Suez **C**anal* *Cape of **G**ood **H**ope* *Bay of **B**engal*
4. Names of religions also begin with capital letters:
   Buddhism *Christianity* *Hinduism* *Islam* *Jainism*
5. The first letter of an adjective formed from a proper name is a capital:
   Chinese (< China) *Indian (< India)* *Pakistani (< Pakistan)*
   British (< Britain) *French (< France)* *West Indian (< West Indies)*
6. You already know that the first letters of the names of days of the week and months of the year are capitals:
   Monday *Friday* *Sunday* *Wednesday*
   January *March* *October* *December*

   But, the first letters of the names of the seasons are usually small letters:
   spring *summer* *autumn* *winter*

7. Initial letters of titles that are a part of a compound name are capitals:
   ***S**ir Donald Bradman* ***H**er Majesty the Queen*
   ***H**is Excellency the Governor of Assam*
   Note that capitals are not used for *the* and *of*, that is, for articles (*the*) and prepositions (*of*).
8. When we spell the names or titles of books, poems, stories, etc, we can use capitals in a number of ways. We can use
   (a) all capitals:
   THE ADVENTURES OF TOM SAWYER
   (b) large and small capitals:
   THE ADVENTURES OF TOM SAWYER
   (c) capital letters for beginning all words excepting prepositions, conjunctions, and *a*, *an* and *the* unless they come at the very beginning of the title or name. This is the most common method used for titles of books, stories, poems and essays:
   *Ali Baba **and the** Forty Thieves*
   But,
   ***The** Adventures **of** Tom Sawyer*
   *Stopping **by** Woods **on a** Snowy Evening*
   But,
   ***On** His Blindness*

Note: Capitals are used for the first letters of prepositions (like *through*) and conjunctions (like *because*) as they contain more than four letters.

9. Capitals are used to begin the names of historical periods and events:
   ***B**ronze **A**ge* ***V**edic **A**ge* ***M**iddle **A**ges* ***F**irst **W**orld **W**ar*
10. The first letter of every sentence is a capital. The first letter after a full stop is also a capital.
    ***A** dog was sitting under the table. **S**o, we were a little scared to enter the room. **T**hen Ram's mother came in and asked us to sit down.*
11. The first letter after a question mark is also usually a capital:
    *How are you? **H**ave you seen a doctor yet.*
    *Who rang the bell? **I** cannot see anybody anywhere.*
12. Usually, the first letter of every line of a poem is a capital, though it might not be the first letter of a sentence:

Spring, the sweet Spring, is the year's pleasant king;
Then blooms each thing, then maids dance in a ring,
Cold doth not sting, the pretty birds do sing,
Cuckoo, jug-jug, pu-we, to-witta-woo!

(Thomas Nash)

Note how a capital 'S' has been used to spell the second 'Spring' in the first line. Sometimes, when we think of a non-living thing as living we use a capital as the first letter of its name. In this line, spring is compared to a 'king'—a human being. Such a use of capitals is usually found in poems.

Rewrite the following sentences, using capitals wherever you think they are necessary:

1. why are you sitting here? are you waiting for somebody?
2. there are many flowers in this garden. can you name a few of them?
3. the name of the book i read a few days ago was treasure island.
4. asia is the largest continent of the world. which is the largest ocean?
5. gautam buddha was a prince.
6. alice's adventures in wonderland is the name of a book written by lewis carroll. The author's real name was charles dodgson. he also wrote a book called through the looking-glass.
7. the greatest king of the mauryan dynasty was ashoka.
8. the second world war lasted for more than four years.
9. pakistan, bangladesh and nepal are amongst india's neighbouring countries.
10. the capital of the arab republic of egypt is cairo.
11. have you read robinson crusoe? do you know it was written by daniel defoe?
12. thirty days hath september,
    april, june and november;
    february has twenty-eight alone.
    all the rest have thirty-one,
    except in a leap year, that's the time
    when february's days are twenty-nine.